ordinary people next door. I began to feel strongly that a haven not of secrecy but of openness would answer the call.

Such a place would also serve as a journalism haven, a place where sources could be protected as part of the law of the land. Free press legislation would be deeply embedded in such a place. Internet freedoms would be part of the modern ether and liberty from prosecution would be standard. I began to have a vision of this haven: a politically independent zone, a place where one could stop running, where whistleblowers might be considered heroes not public enemies, where legal advice would be free and plentiful and Internet access universal. It sounded like Nirvana to me, until I began to realise it might actually be called Iceland.

In the summer of 2009 we were leaked a copy of the Kaupthing Bank Large Loan Book. This was a document revealing every loan over €45 million made by the Icelandic bank. Kaupthing was the largest of Iceland's banks and had suffered a massive decline in the 2008 financial meltdown, eventually becoming insolvent. The bank's motto was 'Think Beyond', and, it appeared, many of the borrowers had taken that motto to heart. Many were insiders, and even though the loans were for enormous sums, many were unsecured. Kaupthing loaned €791.2 million to Exista hf., the company that owned Kaupthing itself. According to the document we leaked, 'the bulk of the loans [to Exista hf.] are unsecured and with no covenants'. Money was lent to the fourth- largest shareholder in Kaupthing, in order that he could buy even more shares in Kaupthing, and the only collateral that he had to provide was those same shares in Kaupthing! A tiny number of individuals were enriching themselves with these loans, money that only ever existed on paper, and the people of Iceland would have to pick up the tab. Two brothers, Ágúst and Lýður Guðmundsson, and companies owned by them, received loans totalling ISK300 billion, which was equivalent to €1.6 billion. Robert Tchenguiz, a member of the board of Exista hf., received loans of ISK330 billion. It won't surprise you to learn that a number of individuals have been arrested, in Iceland and abroad, following the collapse of the Icelandic banking system.

Within twenty-four hours of releasing the document, WikiLeaks was on the receiving end of a legal threat from Kaupthing's lawyers. It stated that we, and our source, could face one year in prison under the Icelandic Banking Secrecy Law. RUV, the Icelandic equivalent of the BBC, was set to go ahead with a leading item on that night's *Seven O'Clock News* about